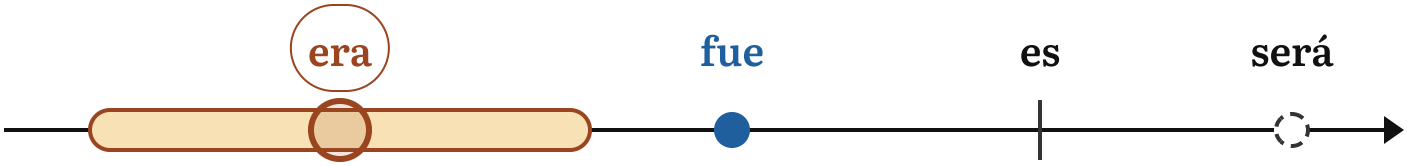
Tense timeline

Both era and fue mean “was”. The difference is the shape of the time.

BACK THEN NOW LATER



Drag along the line, or tap a word on it.

Imperfect · A stretch: how things were, used to be, or what was going on

Other verbs, same shape:

tenía · tener **iba** · ir **hacía** · hacer **estaba** · estar

FROM YOUR OWN SENTENCES

Save words while you read or chat, and your own sentences in this tense show up here.

EXAMPLES

Mi comida favorita **eran** los tacos.
My favorite food was tacos (all through childhood).

De niño **vivía** cerca del mar.
As a kid I lived near the sea.

Leía cuando **sonó** el teléfono.
I was reading (a stretch) when the phone rang (a point).
Both in one sentence

Tap a sentence to hear it.

SOURCES

- RAE–ASALE, Nueva gramática básica de la lengua española (2011): the preterite (pretérito perfecto simple) and the imperfect (pretérito imperfecto).